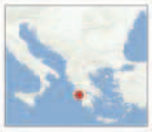
CHRISTIAN NAVIES AGAINST THE TURKS

THE FIRST CHRISTIAN STATE to feel the effects of Ottoman naval power was Venice, thoroughly defeated in a war fought between 1499 and 1503. From then until the battle of Lepanto in 1571, the Christians were unable to challenge Ottoman command of the eastern Mediterranean. However, the galleys of Malta, under the Knights of St. John, harassed Turkish communications, and the failure of the Ottoman siege of the island in 1565 was a major relief for Christian Europe. Efforts to wrest control of North Africa from the Muslims repeatedly failed and the Barbary corsairs of Algiers, Tunis, and Tripoli, acting as Ottoman privateers, were a constant threat in the western Mediterranean. The Ottoman cause was aided by lack of unity between the Christian powers, with Venice and the Habsburgs fixed enemies, and the French mostly allied with the Turks. The battle of Diu, which extended Christian-Muslim conflict into the Indian Ocean, was a reminder that the Mediterranean powers were fighting for control of a backwater, as oceanic voyages opened up new trade routes and ocean-going ships transformed naval warfare.

VENETIAN–OTTOMAN WAR

ZONCHIO



Date August 12–25, 1499
Forces Ottomans: 87 galleys and galliots, c.200 other ships; Venetians: 64 galleys and galliots, c.100 other ships
Losses Unknown

Location Cape Zonchio, Lepanto, Greece

In spring 1499 a Venetian force under Antonio Grimani met an Ottoman fleet under Kemal Reis off Lepanto. Both fleets had a number of great galleys and carracks that provided a high platform for breach-loading iron cannon and primitive handguns, as well as men armed with bows and other traditional missiles. Kemal Reis's flagship, *Göke*, could reputedly carry 700 soldiers. In the first engagement on August 12 *Göke* was boarded by two Venetian carracks, one of them commanded by Andrea Loredano. A fire broke out on *Göke* and all three vessels were burned. Grimani was accused of failing to come to Loredano's aid.

Further actions were fought between the two fleets on August 20, 22, and 25. The overall result was a clear defeat for the Venetians. Grimani was arrested on his return to Venice, but survived to become doge later in life.



Grappling and boarding
This contemporary woodcut shows the central event of the battle of Zonchio, when two Venetian ships grappled the Ottoman flagship, resulting in hand-to-hand fighting and deadly exchanges of arrows.

PORTUGUESE–OTTOMAN WAR

DIU



Date February 1509
Forces Portuguese: 18 ships; Egyptian-Gujerati force: 12 ships
Losses Unknown

Location Diu, western India

After Vasco da Gama's voyage to India in 1498, the Portuguese set out to take over the spice trade between the Indian Ocean and Europe. This was a threat to Egypt, Venice, and the Ottoman Empire, which all profited from the trade. The Ottomans gave the Egyptians galleys to send into the Indian Ocean. The Egyptian squadron joined with the dhows of Gujerati Sultan Mahmud Begada and, in March 1508, intercepted a Portuguese convoy. In the action Lourenço de Almeida, son of Portuguese viceroy Dom Francisco de Almeida, was killed.

Officially replaced as viceroy in December 1508, de Almeida refused to give up command and took his carracks and caravels to seek revenge. He found the Egyptian-Gujerati force in port at Diu. The Portuguese used their cannon to bombard the enemy, then closed to board. The many prisoners taken were vilely mistreated by de Almeida, incensed at his son's death. The battle established the absolute superiority of European ocean-going sailing ships in naval warfare.



Portuguese naval artillery
The swivel-gun was a small anti-personnel weapon with a wide arc of fire, fired at the enemy's deck as one closed to board.

> AS LONG AS YOU MAY BE POWERFUL AT SEA, YOU WILL HOLD INDIA AS YOURS; AND IF YOU DO NOT POSSESS THIS POWER, LITTLE WILL AVAIL YOU A FORTRESS ON THE SHORE.
>
> **FRANCISCO DE ALMEIDA** IN A LETTER TO KING MANUEL OF PORTUGAL AFTER THE VICTORY AT DIU

OTTOMAN–HABSBURG WARS

DJERBA



Date May 1560
Forces Ottomans: 86 galleys or galliots; Christians: 54 galleys, 66 other vessels
Losses Ottomans: none; Christians: 30 ships captured

Location Off coast of Tunisia

In 1560 panic at Muslim raids in the western Mediterranean led various Christian powers, including Genoa, Malta, and Savoy, to support an expedition mounted by Philip II of Spain against North Africa. Led by the Genoese Giovanni Andrea Doria, they captured the island of Djerba. With Djerba and Malta in their hands, they would control access to the western Mediterranean. The Ottomans dispatched a fleet under Grand Admiral Piyale Pasha, who arrived off Djerba to find the Christian ships scattered and half their crews ashore. He attacked immediately and captured half the Christian galleys in a few hours. Doria escaped in a small boat, but thousands were taken prisoner. Piyale returned to Constantinople towing the captured galleys in triumph.